

50 Gideon

The fearful farmer whom God called a mighty man of valour and used to rout Midian with three hundred men.

Gideon was threshing wheat in a winepress, hiding it from Midianite raiders, when the angel of the LORD greeted him as a "mighty man of valour." Gideon felt weak and asked many questions, and God answered with signs and patience. Gideon tore down his father's altar to Baal, gathered an army, and watched God cut it from thirty-two thousand men to three hundred. With trumpets, jars and torches they put the enemy to flight. He refused to be king, but a golden ephod he made became a snare.

At a glance

<i>Name</i>	Hebrew <i>Gid'on</i> , often explained as "hewer"
<i>Other name</i>	Jerubbaal, "let Baal plead" (Judges 6:32)
<i>Family</i>	Son of Joash the Abiezrite, of Manasseh (Judges 6:11, 15)
<i>When</i>	After Deborah; any BC date is rough
<i>Key places</i>	Ophrah, valley of Jezreel, well of Harod
<i>Enemies</i>	Oreb and Zeeb, Zebah and Zalmunna
<i>Sons</i>	Seventy, and Abimelech by a concubine (Judges 8:30–31)
<i>New Testament</i>	Hebrews 11:32 ("Gideon")

"And the angel of the LORD appeared unto him, and said unto him, The LORD is with thee, thou mighty man of valour."

Judges 6:12, KJV

The life of Gideon

Judges gives no calendar dates; on the early chronology the judges span c. 1375–1050 BC. Any date for Gideon is rough.

Seven years	● Midian oppresses Israel Midianites and their allies invade each harvest, destroying crops and livestock. Israel hides in caves and cries to the LORD. <i>Judges 6:1–6</i>
At Ophrah	● Called by God The angel of the LORD finds Gideon threshing wheat. Gideon protests he is the least in his father's house; fire consumes his offering. <i>Judges 6:11–24</i>
That night	● Tears down Baal's altar He breaks down his father's altar to Baal. The townsmen want him killed, but Joash defends him. <i>Judges 6:25–32</i>
In the valley of Jezreel	● Gathers an army The Spirit of the LORD comes on Gideon, and he summons the tribes. He asks for signs with a fleece, and God gives them. <i>Judges 6:33–40</i>
At the well of Harod	● Three hundred chosen God reduces the army from thirty-two thousand to ten thousand, and then to three hundred men who lapped the water. <i>Judges 7:1–8</i>
At night	● Midian is routed After overhearing a Midianite's dream, Gideon attacks. His men blow trumpets, break jars and shout, and the enemy turns on itself. <i>Judges 7:9–22</i>
Across the Jordan	● Pursues the kings "Faint, yet pursuing," he captures and kills Zebah and Zalmunna, and punishes Succoth and Penuel. <i>Judges 7:23–8:21</i>
Forty years	● Rest, ephod and death He refuses the crown but makes an ephod that becomes a snare. The land is quiet forty years, and he dies "in a good old age." <i>Judges 8:22–32</i>

Key activities

Christians read the fleece in different ways. Some see it as weak faith that God kindly answered. Others see it as a sincere request for assurance. Scripture records it without comment, since God had already given Gideon his promise (Judges 6:14–16).

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- I Hid his harvest.** He threshed wheat in a winepress to keep it from the Midianites. *Judges 6:11*

 - 2 Questioned God.** He asked, "if the LORD be with us, why then is all this befallen us?" *Judges 6:13*

 - 3 Confessed his weakness.** "My family is poor in Manasseh, and I am the least in my father's house." *Judges 6:15*

 - 4 Built an altar.** He named it Jehovah-shalom, "the LORD is peace." *Judges 6:22–24*

 - 5 Obeyed by night.** Afraid of his family and the town, he tore down Baal's altar under cover of darkness. *Judges 6:25–27*

 - 6 Earned a new name.** His father said, "if he be a god, let him plead for himself," and called him Jerubbaal. *Judges 6:31–32*

 - 7 Sought signs.** He asked for dew on the fleece and then on the ground, and God did both. *Judges 6:36–40*

 - 8 Trusted God with fewer men.** God said too many soldiers would let Israel say, "Mine own hand hath saved me." *Judges 7:2–8*

 - 9 Led a night attack.** His men cried, "The sword of the LORD, and of Gideon." *Judges 7:16–22*

 - 10 Calmed Ephraim.** He answered their anger with humility, and "their anger was abated toward him." *Judges 8:1–3*

 - 11 Refused the crown.** "I will not rule over you, neither shall my son rule over you: the LORD shall rule over you." *Judges 8:22–23*

 - 12 Made a golden ephod.** He set it up in Ophrah, and "all Israel went thither a whoring after it." *Judges 8:24–27*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Gideon.

Old Testament

Judges 6–8	The main account
Judges 8:33–9:57	After his death, Abimelech kills his brothers
1 Samuel 12:11	"Jerubbaal" among the deliverers God sent
2 Samuel 11:21	Called "Jerubbesheth," Baal replaced by "shame"
Psalms 83:9–12	Enemies like Oreb, Zeeb, Zebah and Zalmunna
Isaiah 9:4; 10:26	"The day of Midian" recalled as God's saving power

New Testament

Hebrews 11:32–34	"Gideon" first among judges made strong out of weakness
Echo: 2 Corinthians 12:9	"My strength is made perfect in weakness"
Echo: 2 Corinthians 4:7	Some link the broken jars to "earthen vessels"

For discussion

- Observe:* How did God reduce Gideon's army, and what reason did he give (Judges 7:2–7)?
- Understand:* God called Gideon a "mighty man of valour" while he was hiding. What does that show about how God sees people?
- Apply:* Gideon's first act of obedience was at home, at his father's altar. What needs to change close to home before you serve more widely?
- Apply:* Gideon's ephod turned a victory into a snare. What good gift or success could pull your heart away from God?